

NORMANDY

THE BLOODY POCKET

D-DAY TO FALAISE 1944

Playbook

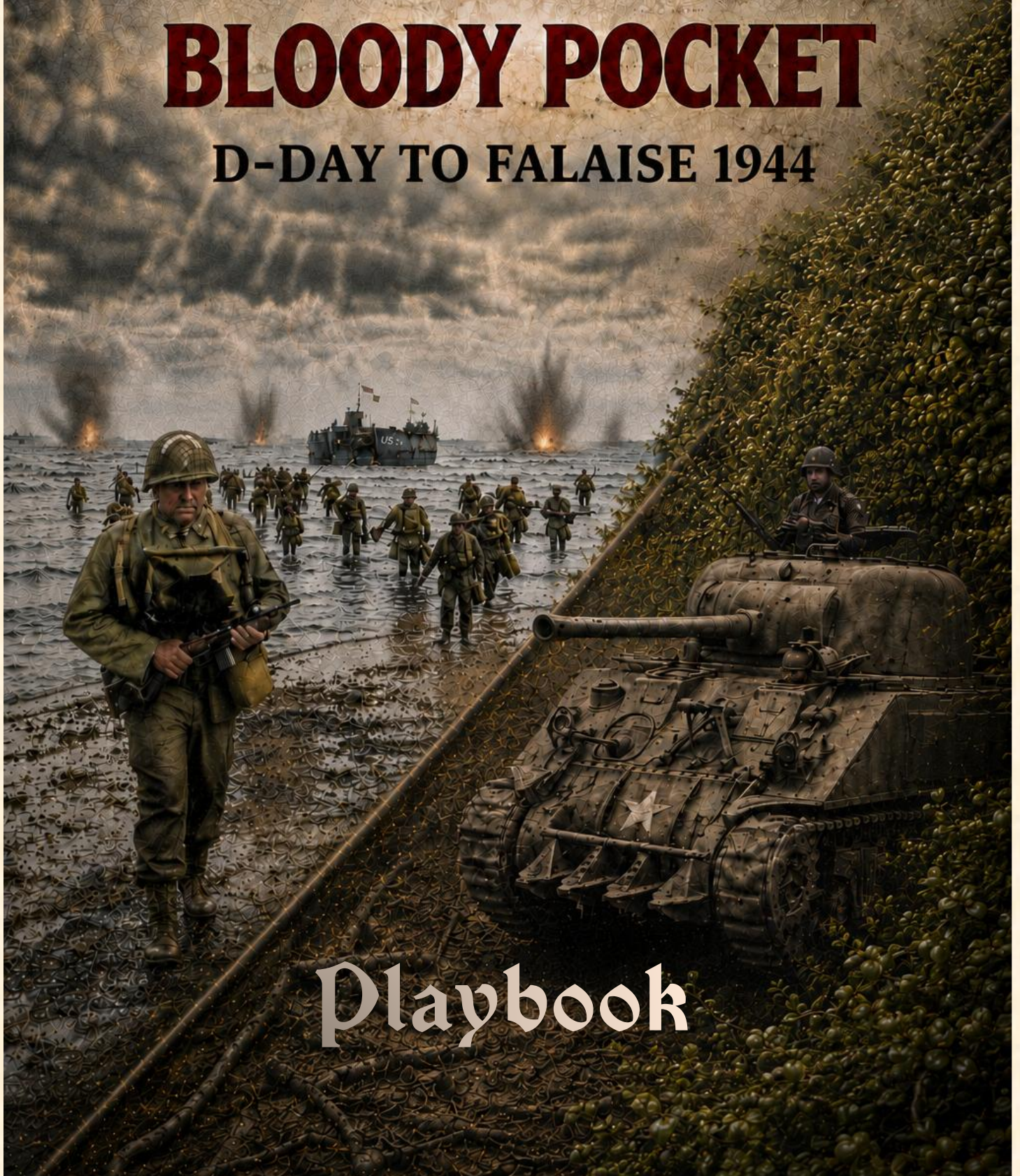


TABLE OF CONTENTS

TABLE OF CONTENTS	2
Event Card Historical Background.....	2
Designer Notes.....	13

Event Card Historical Background

Often in *States of Siege* games the historical text was printed on the cards. In *Normandy: The Bloody Pocket*, there was insufficient space to do this without using a prohibitively small font. Instead we present the background historical text here.

CARD 1 D-Day Landings First Wave

The operation was the largest amphibious invasion in world history, with over 160,000 troops landing on 6 June 1944. 195,700 Allied naval and merchant navy personnel in over 5,000 ships were involved.

The landings took place along a 50-mile (80 km) stretch of the Normandy coast divided into five sectors: Utah, Omaha, Gold, Juno and Sword.

CARD 2 D-Day Landings Second Wave

Very little went as planned during the landing at Omaha Beach. Difficulties in navigation caused the majority of landing craft to miss their targets throughout the day.

The defenses were unexpectedly strong, and inflicted heavy casualties on landing US troops. Under heavy fire, the engineers struggled to clear the beach obstacles, requiring a second wave assault to clear the beach

CARD 3 *Carentan*

The objective of the attacking American forces following D-Day was consolidation of the U.S. beachheads (Utah Beach and Omaha Beach) around the town of Carentan, and establishment of a continuous defensive line against expected German counterattacks.

The defending German force attempted to hold the town long enough to allow reinforcements en route from the south to arrive, prevent or delay the merging of the lodgments

CARD 4 *21st Panzer Counter Attack*

The 21st Panzer Division's counter-attack on June 6–7 1944, was the most significant German armored response to the D-Day landings, aimed at stopping the British advance and preventing them from capturing the critical city of Caen.

Though initially successful in pushing between Sword and Juno beaches, the attack was beaten back by intense Allied anti-tank fire and Allied air superiority, resulting in heavy losses for the Germans.

CARD 5 *Panzer Meyer*

Kurt Meyer, nicknamed "Pantermeyer" was commanding general of the 12th SS Panzer Division *Hitler Jugend*. He regularly visited the front lines on a motorcycle. He sustained eighteen broken bones and four concussions during his career, testament to his daredevil personality.

CARD 6 *French Resistance*

The French Résistance played a significant role in facilitating the Allies' rapid advance through France following the invasion of Normandy on 6 June 1944, and the lesser-known invasion of Provence on 15 August, by providing military intelligence on the German defenses known as the Atlantic Wall and on Wehrmacht deployments and orders of battle.

The Résistance also planned, coordinated, and executed acts of sabotage on the electrical power grid, transportation facilities, and telecommunications networks.

CARD 7 *Cotentin Offensive*

The campaign in the Cotentin Peninsula (6-30 June 1944) was the first major Allied advance after the D-Day landings, and ended with the capture of the port of Cherbourg, seen by the Allies as one of the most important objectives of Operation Overlord.

The capture of a major port was seen as an essential part of the post D-Day build-up in France, and the seaborne assault had been extended west to Utah Beach to allow for an early advance towards Cherbourg. Captured on June 26-29, the Germans had comprehensively wrecked the Cherbourg port facilities, making it inoperable initially.

CARD 8 *Villers Bocage*

The battle of Villers-Bocage was the result of a British attempt to improve their position by exploiting a temporary vulnerability in the German defences to the west of the city of Caen.

The town was briefly captured but the inexperienced XXX Corps commander, Gerard Buckner, made several errors thereafter, not least the mishandling of 7th Armored Division, resulting in the loss of Villers-Bocage, which was not captured again until August.

The British withdrawal marked the end of the post D-Day "scramble for ground" and the start of a grinding attritional battle for Caen.

CARD 9 Michael Wittmann

Michael Wittmann (April 22, 1914 – August 8, 1944) was a German Waffen-SS tank commander. Wittmann is most famous for his ambush of elements of the British 7th Armoured Division, during the Battle of Villers-Bocage on 13 June 1944.

While in command of a single Tiger tank he destroyed up to 14 tanks and 15 personnel carriers along with 2 antitank guns in the space of 15 minutes.

CARD 10 V1 Rockets

The Fieseler Fi 103, better known as the V-1 'Buzz Bomb', also colloquially known in Britain as the 'Doodlebug', was an early pulse-jet-powered example of what would later be called a cruise missile.

The V-1 was developed at Peenemünde Airfield by the German Luftwaffe during the Second World War. The first V-1 was launched at London on 13 June 1944, one week after (and prompted by) the successful Allied landings in Europe.

At its peak, over a hundred V-1s a day were fired at southeast England; 9,521 in total, decreasing in number as sites were overrun until October 1944, when the last V-1 site in range of Britain was captured by Allied forces.

CARD 11 Siege of Cherbourg

By June 20th, the American divisions were within striking distance of Cherbourg. The garrison commander, Lieutenant General Karl-Wilhelm von Schlieben, had 21,000 men but many of these were hastily drafted naval personnel or from labour units.

The fighting troops who had retreated to Cherbourg, were tired and disorganised. Food, fuel and ammunition were short. The Luftwaffe dropped a few supplies, but these were mostly items such as Iron Crosses, intended to bolster the garrison's morale.

Nevertheless, von Schlieben rejected a summons to surrender and began carrying out demolitions to deny the port to the Allies.

CARD 12 Operation Bagration

Operation Bagration was the codename for the Soviet 1944 Belorussian Strategic Offensive Operation during World War II, which cleared German forces from the Belorussian SSR and eastern Poland between 22 June and 19 August 1944.

Bagration was timed to coincide with the Allied breakout from Normandy partly in order to restrict the flow of reinforcements and supplies to the western front

CARD 13 *The Great Storm*

The Storm of 19-20 June 1944: The weather was always an unknown factor. Storms in the English Channel have always been violent, with the wind whipping the waves in the confined area between Normandy and England.

The great storm succeeded in doing what the Germans had not been able to do, destroy the great "mulberry" artificial harbors. It also grounded the Allied Air Forces allowing reinforcements and supplies to move around in Normandy unimpeded.

CARD 14 *Operation Epsom*

Operation Epsom, also known as the First Battle of the Odon, was a British offensive that took place between 26 and 30 June 1944, during the Battle of Normandy.

The offensive was intended to outflank and seize the German-occupied city of Caen, a major Allied objective in the early stages of the invasion of northwest Europe.

Preceded by attacks to secure lines of advance, Operation Epsom was launched early on 26 June, with units of the 15th (Scottish) Infantry Division advancing behind a rolling artillery barrage. Air cover was sporadic for much of the operation, as poor weather in the United Kingdom forced the last-minute cancellation of bomber support.

CARD 15 *Operation Windsor*

Operation Windsor was a Canadian offensive launched between 4–5 July 1944.

The attack was undertaken by the 3rd Canadian Infantry Division in an attempt to capture the Norman town of Carpiquet and the adjacent airfield from German forces.

The attack was originally intended to take place during the later stages of Operation Epsom, as a means of protecting the eastern flank of the main assault. It was postponed and launched the following week.

CARD 16 *Battle of the Bocage*

The Normandy bocage—a landscape of ancient, thick hedgerows on top of high earthen embankments—presented severe, unforeseen tactical problems for Allied forces following the June 1944 D-Day landings. This terrain transformed the Norman countryside into a maze-like battlefield that favored German defenders and stalled the Allied advance for weeks.

Tanks, particularly Shermans, could not easily cross the banks. Attempting to climb them exposed their vulnerable, thin underbellies to anti-tank fire. Single, disabled tanks often blocked the narrow sunken lanes, stalling armored columns.

These challenges necessitated the invention of the "Rhino" tanks, featuring steel cutters welded to the front to break through the hedges, and forced the development of new close-quarters tactics to overcome the defensive deadlock.

CARD 17 *Nebelwerfers*

The Nebelwerfer ("Smoke Mortar") was a German multiple rocket launcher system that played a significant role as tactical artillery during the 1944 Normandy Campaign.

Known by Allied troops as "Screaming Mimis" or "Moaning Minnies" due to the distinctive, terrifying sound of incoming rockets, these weapons were used in large numbers to disrupt Allied troop concentrations.

CARD 18 *Operation Charnwood*

Operation Charnwood was an Anglo-Canadian offensive that took place from 8–9 July 1944.

The operation was intended to at least partially capture the German-occupied French city of Caen, which was an important Allied objective during the opening stages of Operation Overlord. It was also hoped that the attack would pre-empt the transfer of German armoured units from the Anglo-Canadian sector to the lightly-screened American sector, where a major US offensive was being planned. The British and Canadians advanced on a broad front and by the evening of the second day had taken Caen up to the Orne and Odon rivers.

On the night before the ground assault, nearly 500 RAF Bomber Command aircraft dropped over 2,000 tons of bombs on Caen. While it boosted Allied morale, it was controversial as it leveled much of the historic city center and the resulting rubble hindered Allied tank movement.

CARD 19 88mm Flak

The German 88mm Flak (Flugabwehrkanone) was a pivotal, dual-purpose gun in Normandy, 1944, renowned for its lethality as an anti-tank weapon.

Allied tankers greatly feared the "eighty-eight" for its ability to penetrate armor from long ranges. It was used in both defensive beach positions and to counter Allied armored breakthroughs in the hedgerow country.

Deployed in hidden, entrenched, or bunker positions, often covering key road junctions, the bocage (hedgerow) terrain made them hard to locate and destroy.

CARD 20 Operation Goodwood

Operation Goodwood was an attack launched on 18 July 1944, by the British-Canadian army to the east of the city of Caen. British VIII Corps led the attack with three armoured divisions, supported by British I Corps on the eastern flank and the Canadian II Corps on the western flank, who were launching their own attack codenamed Operation Atlantic, to capture the remainder of Caen.

When Operation Goodwood ended on 20 July, the armoured divisions had broken through the initial German defences and had advanced 7 miles before coming to a halt in front of the Bourguébus Ridge, although armoured cars had penetrated further south and over the ridge.

CARD 21 Operation Jupiter

Operation Jupiter was an offensive by VIII Corps of the British Second Army from 10 to 11 July 1944.

The objective of the 43rd (Wessex) Infantry Division was to capture the villages of Baron-sur-Odon, Fontaine-Étoupefour, Château de Fontaine-Étoupefour and to recapture Hill 112.

The British advance went well at first but fighting for Hill 112 took all day and the village of Maltot changed hands several times.

On 11 July, German counter-attacks forced the British off the top of Hill 112 to positions on the north-facing slope. The operation was a tactical failure for VIII Corps but a strategic success for the Allies, attrition having reduced the II SS Panzer Corps to a condition from which it never recovered.

CARD 22 Naval Gunfire

After the initial D-Day landings, naval gunfire support remained a vital part of the Normandy campaign for nearly two months.

While land-based artillery gradually took over, heavy Allied warships continued to act as a "floating heavy artillery," capable of striking targets deep inland that land batteries couldn't reach.

During Operation Epsom (26–30 June) and Operation Charnwood (7–9 July), the massive 16-inch guns of HMS *Rodney* and HMS *Nelson* were used to "hammer" German Panzer divisions assembling for counter-attacks.

Even as late as 23 July (D+46), warships were still providing support for the Allied advance.

CARD 23 *Sherman Firefly*

The Sherman Firefly was the British variant of the American Sherman tank, fitted with the powerful British 17 pounder anti-tank gun as its main weapon.

Originally conceived as a stopgap until future British tank designs came into service, the Sherman Firefly became the most common vehicle with the 17 pounder in World War II. It soon became highly valued as the only British tank capable of defeating the Panther and Tiger tanks it faced in Normandy at standard combat ranges.

CARD 24 *Operation Spring*

Operation Spring (25-27 July 1944) was an offensive operation conducted by II Canadian Corps during the Normandy campaign.

The plan was intended to create pressure on the German forces operating on the British and Canadian front simultaneously to the American *Operation Cobra*, an attempt to break out from the Normandy lodgement.

Operation Spring was one of the costliest and most controversial Canadian operations of the Normandy campaign. While it failed to capture its primary objectives, it served a critical strategic purpose by pinning German Panzer divisions in the east to facilitate the American breakout in the west, known as Operation Cobra.

CARD 25 *Operation Cobra*

Operation Cobra was the codename for the offensive launched by 1st US Army eight weeks after the D-Day landings.

Lieutenant General Omar Bradley's intention was to take advantage of the German preoccupation with British and Canadian activity around the town of Caen, and punch through the German defenses pinning in his troops while his opponent was distracted and unbalanced.

Once a corridor had been created, the US Army would then be able to advance into Brittany, rolling up the German flanks and freeing itself of the constraints imposed by operating in the Norman bocage countryside.

Operation Cobra shifted the war from a battle of attrition in the hedgerows to a war of movement. It led directly to the near-encirclement of the German Seventh Army in the Falaise Pocket and the eventual liberation of Paris in August 1944.

CARD 26 *Sherman "Rhino"*

A Rhino tank was the US nickname for Allied tanks fitted with hedgerow-breaching "tusks".

By cutting apart the three-beam, tetrahedral steel anti-tank obstacles that had been placed by the Germans on the Normandy beaches before the landing, the Americans recycled the obstacles' steel beams into many-pronged, sharp, tusk-like assemblies to attach to the front of their M4 Sherman medium and M5 Stuart light tanks.

This method of cutting through hedgerows was extremely effective in the bocage terrain of the area, where hedges were a serious obstacle for tanks.

CARD 27 *Hitler Assassination Attempt*

The 20 July plot of 1944 was an attempt to assassinate Adolf Hitler, Führer of the Third Reich, inside his Wolf's Lair field headquarters near Rastenburg, East Prussia.

The plot was the culmination of the efforts of several groups in the German Resistance to overthrow the Nazi regime. The failure of both the assassination and the military coup d'état which was planned to follow it led to the arrest of at least 7,000 people by the Gestapo.

Believing the traditional military elite to be a "thing of the past," following the attempt, Hitler took radical steps to ensure the military was completely subservient to the Nazi Party for the remainder of the war.

Hitler's distrust intensified his tendency to micromanage military operations, often overriding professional advice from his remaining generals.

CARD 28 Upgrade Armies

Initially, the German tactical defensive scheme and the difficult hedgerow terrain outmatched the Allies' infantry, armour artillery and air power.

It took time for the Allies to learn how to fight in Normandy, for example by improved co-ordination between tanks and infantry/air support. Combined with the increasing expertise of the commanders, eventually the Allied armies learned how to defeat the Germans at the tactical level.

Additionally, two new armies were activated in July/August 1944: US 3rd Army and Canadian 1st Army.

CARD 29 Brittany Offensive

While the bulk of the Allied forces moved eastward toward Paris, George Patton's Third Army moved in the opposite direction to secure the Brittany Peninsula after breaking through German formations at Avranches.

By removing German control of Brittany, additional ports would become available for the Allies' use. Patton's first move called for the Fourth Armored Division to move southward, taking Rennes on August 4th and Nantes on August 6th. This initial move trapped four German divisions at the peninsula. Then the Americans turned back north, taking the small port of St. Malo on 14 Aug after three days of fierce German resistance.

CARD 30 Operation Bluecoat

Operation Bluecoat was an attack by the British Second Army from 30 July 1944 to 7 August 1944.

The geographical objectives of the attack were to secure the key road junction of Vire and the high ground of Mont Pinçon. Strategically, the attack was made to support the American exploitation of their breakout on the western flank of the Normandy beachhead.

Operation Bluecoat was an Allied victory, though it came at a high cost: The British VIII Corps alone suffered over 5,100 casualties and lost approximately 250 tanks during the operation.

CARD 31 Brittany Offensive II

At Brest, General Middleton slowly wore down General Ramcke and his airborne troops with a series of small attacks, while Allied bombers from Britain bombed the city.

Brest fell to the Allies on 19 Aug, though still at a cost of 10,000 casualties.

Lorient and St. Nazaire were under siege for the remainder of the war. General Fahrmbacher held on to Lorient until 10 May 1945, and General Junck surrendered his garrison at Saint Nazaire on 11 May.

CARD 32 Mortain Counter-Attack

Operation Lüttich was the codename given to the German counterattack, which took place around the American positions near Mortain from 7 August to 13 August 1944.

The assault was ordered by Adolf Hitler, to eliminate the gains made by the 1st US Army during Operation Cobra and the subsequent weeks, and by reaching the coast in the region of Avranches at the base of the Cotentin peninsula, cut off the units of the 3rd US Army which had advanced into Brittany.

Instead of cutting off Patton, Operation Lüttich actually played into Allied hands. By concentrating their remaining armor in a narrow salient at Mortain, the Germans made it easier for the Allies to encircle them, directly leading to the catastrophic defeat at the Falaise Pocket.

CARD 33 Operation Totalize

Operation Totalize was an offensive launched by Allied troops of the 1st Canadian Army from August 8 to August 13, 1944.

The intention was to break through the German defences south of Caen on the eastern flank of the Allied positions in Normandy and exploit success by driving south to capture the high ground north of the city of Falaise.

The overall goal was to precipitate the collapse of the entire German front, and cut off the retreat of German forces fighting further west.

While Totalize fell about 9 miles (14 km) short of Falaise itself, it significantly weakened the German front and seized the critical Verrières Ridge. The Allies suffered over 1,200 casualties and lost 146 tanks.

Operation Totalize set the stage for the follow-up Operation Tractable, which would finally close the "Falaise-Argentan Gap" and trap the German Seventh Army.

CARD 34 Operation Tractable

Operation Tractable was the final offensive conducted by Canadian Army and Polish Army troops as part of the Battle of Normandy.

The goal of this operation was to capture the strategically important French town of Falaise. This operation was undertaken by the Polish 1st Armoured Division and the 1st Canadian Army.

While the Canadians cleared Falaise, the 1st Polish Armoured Division under General Stanisław Maczek was ordered to race east to link up with American forces moving north from Argentan.

Operation Tractable resulted in the destruction of the German military presence in Normandy. Though some German units managed to escape during the delays in closing the gap, the Allies captured roughly 50,000 prisoners and left the valley floor littered with thousands of destroyed vehicles and dead horses.

CARD 35 Hitler Intervention – ULTRA

Hitler often displayed his tendency to issue detailed orders far below the strategic level, and he divided responsibility for military operations among the land, air, and naval commanders, who would answer not to a theatre commander but ultimately to himself.

The problem was compounded by the existence of Allied codebreaking—codenamed ULTRA.

This intelligence - derived from cracking the German Enigma codes at Bletchley Park—was perhaps the Allies' greatest invisible weapon during the Normandy campaign. It allowed Allied commanders to read the "mind" of the German High Command, often seeing their orders before the frontline units even received them.

CARD 36 Hitler Intervention

Hitler's personal interference in Normandy is often cited as a primary reason for the rapid collapse of the German front. He prioritized political control and "no retreat" orders over professional military strategy, which frequently paralyzed his generals.

Examples of some of the interventions include:

- Delays in releasing Panzer units from Strategic Reserves
- No retreat/"Standfast" orders
- Declaring port and other cities "Fortresses" to be held at all costs
- Orders for counter-attacks, e.g., at Mortain

CARD 37 Patton

Following the Normandy invasion, Patton was placed in command of the U.S. 3rd Army, which was on the extreme right (west) of the Allied land forces.

Beginning at noon on August 1, 1944, he led this army during the late stages of Operation Cobra, the breakout from earlier slow fighting in the Normandy hedgerows.

3rd Army simultaneously attacked west (into Brittany), south, east towards the Seine, and north, assisting in trapping several hundred thousand German soldiers in the Chambois pocket, between Falaise and Argentan.

CARD 38 Model Takes Command

After Rommel was wounded Günther "Hans" von Kluge took over as commander of Army Group B.

He found that German forces moving towards Normandy were constantly beset by Allied fighter-bomber attacks. In August, after the failed coup attempt by Stauffenberg, Kluge was recalled to Berlin and replaced by Model.

Often called "Hitler's Fireman" for his ability to stabilize crumbling fronts, Model took command of both OB West and Army Group B on 17 August 1944. By the time he arrived, the German 7th Army was already nearly surrounded in the Falaise Pocket.

CARD 39 Tactical Redeployment

To counter the total Allied air supremacy (the "Jabos"), the Germans developed a sophisticated system of nocturnal logistics and camouflage. By late June 1944, any movement during the day was considered a "death sentence," forcing the Wehrmacht to become a purely nocturnal army.

Moving fuel and ammunition was the greatest challenge, leading to several "workarounds", including underwater bridges, and tactical dispersal (spacing vehicles hundreds of yards apart).

Whenever possible, relocating units would place mobile 20mm or 37mm anti-aircraft guns (Flakpanzers) in the center of the column to bait and ambush low-flying Allied fighters.

The Germans used the extensive French rail tunnel network as underground barracks and repair shops. Trains would hide in tunnels during the day, perform maintenance, and then dash to the next tunnel during the few hours of true darkness.

CARD 40 Canadian 4th Armored Division

The 4th Canadian Armoured Division was the final Canadian division committed to the Normandy campaign, landing on the beaches at Courseulles and Bernières between 24 and 31 July 1944.

It participated in operations Totalize and Tractable.

The formation faced significant criticism during and after the Normandy campaign, particularly regarding its leadership and tactical execution. The division was often cited as a "green" formation that struggled to adapt to the brutal reality of the German defense.

The most direct criticism fell on the division's senior leadership: Major-General George Kitching was removed from command of the division on 21 August 1944 by Lieutenant-General Guy Simonds. Simonds felt Kitching lacked the "drive" and tactical flexibility required to keep the momentum going during the final stages of the Falaise Gap battles.

CARD 41 Falaise Pocket

The battle of the Falaise Pocket, fought from 12–21 August 1944, was the decisive engagement of the Battle of Normandy.

Taking its name from the area around the town of Falaise within which the German Seventh and Fifth Panzer Armies became encircled by the advancing Western Allies, the battle is also referred to as the Falaise Gap after the corridor which the Germans sought to maintain to allow their escape.

The battle resulted in the destruction of the bulk of Germany's forces west of the River Seine and opened the way to Paris and the German border.

CARD 42 Bradley Halt Order

One of the most controversial decisions of the campaign was Bradley's order to halt Patton's 3rd army at Argentan.

It stopped the U.S. XV Corps of Patton's 3rd Army at Argentan and thus left the "Falaise Gap" open for several critical days, allowing a significant portion of the German military to escape encirclement.

It is likely the real reason Bradley halted Patton was not fears over accidental clashes with the British but an appreciation that with powerful German formations still effective at that stage of the battle, the Americans lacked the means to defend an early blocking position and would have suffered an "embarrassing and gratuitous setback" at the hands of the retreating Fallschirmjäger and 2nd and 12th SS Panzer Divisions.

CARD 43 Allied Artillery

Allied artillery was arguably the single most lethal element of the Normandy campaign, often described by German veterans as more terrifying than aerial bombardment.

In the final days of the Falaise Pocket (12–21 August 1944), Allied artillery transformed a narrow escape corridor into a "Killing Ground". As German forces desperately funneled through the remaining gaps, they were subjected to a concentrated, multi-national bombardment that virtually annihilated their remaining heavy equipment.

The final escape route—a 7km stretch along the Dives River between Trun and Chambois—became known as the "Corridor of Death".

CARD 44 Polish 1st Armored Division

The 1st Polish Armoured Division (nicknamed the "Black Devils" by German forces) played a legendary and sacrificial role in the final stages of the Normandy campaign.

Commanded by Major General Stanisław Maczek, the division landed in Normandy in late July and was fully operational by 1 August 1944.

The division made its combat debut on 8 August, fighting alongside the II Canadian Corps in the drive south from Caen.

Operation Totalize: The division made its combat debut on 8 August, fighting alongside the II Canadian Corps in the drive south from Caen.

Identity: The soldiers wore plumed iron helmets and wings as their insignia, a tribute to the 16th-century Polish Hussars. Many were veterans of the 1939 Polish and 1940 French campaigns who had escaped to Britain to continue the fight

CARD 45 Desperate Defense

The German escape attempts from the Falaise Gap were characterized by "blind, desperate fury." By August 19, the pocket had shrunk to a 10-mile strip, and the only way out was through a gauntlet of Allied fire.

On the night of 19–20 August, remnants of the 1st and 12th SS Panzer Divisions launched a suicidal "battering ram" attack to force open the bridge at Chambois. Tanks, half-tracks, and even civilian cars were driven directly at Allied lines in the dark.

Perhaps the most desperate fighting occurred as German units tried to break out by attacking the 1st Polish Armoured Division from below "The Mace" (Hill 262), while the 2nd SS Panzer Corps attacked from the outside to help them.

German infantry, having lost their heavy weapons, crawled up the steep slopes of Mount Ormel under a "curtain" of Allied artillery fire.

CARD 46 Hitler Intervention – Alençon Counter-Attack

As the US XV Corps (part of Patton's 3rd Army) raced north from Le Mans to capture Alençon, Hitler ordered a massive armored strike to cut them off and destroy them in detail.

Hitler's goal was to stop the "left hook" of the Allied breakout. He ordered the Panzer Group Eberbach to assemble near Alençon and launch a northward strike toward Sées.

Eberbach, furious with Hitler's continuing fantasy, replied with the tank strengths of his divisions: 12SS had thirty, 2nd Panzer twenty-five, 116th Panzer 15 and 9th Panzer was down to a company of panzer grenadiers.

The failure of this counter-attack signaled the end of any German hope of "cutting the Allied line." It forced the Germans into a purely defensive mindset, leading directly to their encirclement in the Falaise Pocket.

CARD 47 Red Ball Express

The Red Ball Express was the logistical lifeline that allowed Patton's 3rd Army to maintain its legendary speed during the breakout from Normandy.

By late August 1944, the US Army had advanced so fast that they had outrun their supply lines, which were still rooted at the Normandy beaches.

At its peak, the Red Ball Express utilized nearly 6,000 trucks (mostly the iconic 2.5-ton "Deuce and a Half") and moved up to 12,500 tonnes of supplies in a single day.

The term "Red Ball" was a long-standing American railroad slang term used to describe priority express freight.

CARD 48 Falaise Gap Closed

On August 19, 1944, the "closing" of the Falaise Gap began in earnest.

It was a day of chaotic, violent collisions as the Allied "jaws" finally snapped shut on the remnants of the German 7th Army.

The 1st Polish Armoured Division seized the summit of Mount Ormel (Hill 262), which the Poles nicknamed "The Mace."

In the early evening, the southern and northern Allied pincers finally touched.

While the map showed the gap as closed, thousands of Germans were still inside and spent August 19 in a state of total panic.

With the roads blocked by destroyed vehicles at the Moissy Ford and St. Lambert, the pocket became a "killing ground." Allied artillery and RAF Typhoons pounded the trapped German columns relentlessly.

Designer Notes

Back in 2011, after having played several of the VPG *States of Siege* games - *Lost Cause* and *We Must Tell the Emperor* among them - I noted that the system was predominantly designed for grand sweeps of history, often spanning many years, or even centuries, at a high level of abstraction. So I got to wondering: "Could this game system be scaled down to the operational level?". The result I believe is yes, hence *Normandy: The Bloody Pocket*, which I hope will be the first of a number of titles, adapting this great solitaire system to operational level campaigns.

The prototype was duly completed, using scissors, a printer and glue, and the rulebook sent over to Alan Emrich and John Welch at VPG. The feedback was very positive, but then I needed to test the game to its limits.

Sadly, at that point, work and family commitments got in the way, and the demise of VPG meant that the project got left for 15 years, until now.

Having seen the rejuvenation of interest in the series, with reprints of *Ottoman Sunset* and *Hapsburg Eclipse*, among others, in addition to great new games from Ben Madison, and the David Kennedy substack (SoS), now that I have a bit more time on my hands I wondered if I couldn't revisit the game. Luckily I found all the old electronic files in my email outbox so I was able to redo all the artwork by using the old material as a starting point.

Well, 15 years on and AI is there to help with creating the graphics for a prototype, which I put into *TableTop Simulator* and Vassal, and, voila, we have a game!

So what were the design considerations?

First and foremost, I wanted the game to model two things that aren't always evident in WW2 simulations: i) Hitler's interference in operational matters, and ii) the correct employment of reserves.

Second, it needed to play fast, around 2 hours max. Like many, I no longer seem to have the attention span to play solitaire games (or any games) for hours on end. I wanted it to be quick and also give the player as many decisions each turn as possible.

Thirdly, it needed to model the situation in Normandy as accurately as possible, especially from the German perspective; you can hold the Allies very effectively for the first half of the campaign, but your position will quickly deteriorate thereafter. This was the historical dynamic I was looking for.

So how does the game play out?

At first, things will seem fairly comfortable; the Allies will make little progress, and there are plenty of opportunities for German counter-attacks. In fact, if a lot of German reinforcements appear too early you can feel like you have too much strength. That can be as dangerous as the opposite, where the Allied offensives occur earlier than is common.

This is where avoiding over-committing reserves too soon, despite the temptation, can be the difference between victory and defeat.

Early on, there will be opportunities to rotate panzer formations out of the line for refit, add actions to the reserve and possibly even build some Fortified Villages. But, alas, that situation will not persist.

By the second half of the game, losses are starting to have a major effect; resources, especially fuel, are running low, Hitler is getting increasingly grumpy (and, increasingly, interfering with operational matters) and there simply aren't enough actions each turn to do everything that needs to be done.

The situation, as it progresses towards the end of the game, will become increasingly desperate, especially once Patton's 3rd US Army is activated and all the Allied Armies are upgraded.

The opportunities for counter-attack diminish, not least for lack of oil, and the Allied advance will start to seem unstoppable. As the defeats and retreats increase in frequency, the game becomes a balancing act between holding the Allies back and, at the same time, trying to avoid being relieved of command by Hitler. This becomes even more problematic following the Assassination attempt on Hitler (if that occurs in the early part of the game, a tough job just became tougher.)

All that creates a certain tension in the game. And that is what I was striving for.

